

Psalms 40

I Waited Patiently

I waited patiently for the Lord
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 I waited patiently for the LORD; and he inclined unto me, and heard my cry.
- 2 He brought me up also out of an horrible pit, out of the miry clay, and set my feet upon a rock, and established my goings.
- 3 And he hath put a new song in my mouth, even praise unto our God: many shall see it, and fear, and shall trust in the LORD.
- 4 Blessed is that man that maketh the LORD his trust, and respecteth not the proud, nor such as turn aside to lies.
- 5 Many, O LORD my God, are thy wonderful works which thou hast done, and thy thoughts which are to us-ward: they cannot be reckoned up in order unto thee: if I would declare and speak of them, they are more than can be numbered.
- 6 Sacrifice and offering thou didst not desire; mine ears hast thou opened: burnt offering and sin offering hast thou not required.
- 7 Then said I, Lo, I come: in the volume of the book it is written of me,
- 8 I delight to do thy will, O my God: yea, thy law is within my heart.
- 9 I have preached righteousness in the great congregation: lo, I have not refrained my lips, O LORD, thou knowest.
- 10 I have not hid thy righteousness within my heart; I have declared thy faithfulness and thy salvation: I have not concealed thy lovingkindness and thy truth from the great congregation.
- 11 Withhold not thou thy tender mercies from me, O LORD: let thy lovingkindness and thy truth continually preserve me.
- 12 For innumerable evils have compassed me about: mine iniquities have taken hold upon me, so that I am not able to look up; they are more than the hairs of mine head: therefore my heart faileth me.
- 13 Be pleased, O LORD, to deliver me: O LORD, make haste to help me.
- 14 Let them be ashamed and confounded together that seek after my soul to destroy it; let them be driven backward and put to shame that wish me evil.
- 15 Let them be desolate for a reward of their shame that say unto me, Aha, aha.
- 16 Let all those that seek thee rejoice and be glad in thee: let such as love thy salvation say continually, The LORD be magnified.
- 17 But I am poor and needy; yet the Lord thinketh upon me: thou art my help and my deliverer; make no tarrying, O my God.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 40 opens with testimony of deliverance that came only after patient waiting—God set the psalmist’s feet on a rock and put a new song in his mouth—then celebrates that God desires obedience and a willing heart over mere ritual sacrifice, language the writer of Hebrews (10:5–7) applies directly to Christ. The psalm then shifts into urgent, present-tense petition as fresh troubles surround the psalmist even after past deliverance. Henry observes that praise and petition are woven together here, showing that remembered deliverance fuels present prayer rather than replacing the need for it.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

He waited patiently for the Lord, who inclined to him and heard his cry, bringing him up out of a horrible pit and miry clay, setting his feet upon a rock and establishing his steps. God put a new song in his mouth, and many will see it, fear, and trust in the Lord.

Verse 4-5

Blessed is the man who makes the Lord his trust and does not turn to the proud or to those who go astray with lies. God’s wonderful works and thoughts toward His people are more than can be numbered or declared.

Verse 6-8

Sacrifice and offering, as such, God did not desire; instead He prepared ears to hear (a body, per Hebrews 10). Burnt offering and sin offering were not what He required; so the psalmist says, “Lo, I come... I delight to do thy will, O my God: yea, thy law is within my heart.”

Verse 9-10

He has preached righteousness in the great congregation and has not restrained his lips; he has declared God’s faithfulness and salvation, not concealing His lovingkindness and truth from the great congregation.

Verse 11-13

A plea that God not withhold His tender mercies, for innumerable evils have surrounded him, his iniquities have taken hold of him, and his heart fails; he asks God to be pleased to deliver him and make haste to help him.

Verse 14-17

He prays that those seeking to destroy his soul be confounded, and those who mock him with “Aha, aha” be desolate, while those who seek the Lord rejoice and say, “The Lord be magnified.” Though he is poor and needy, the Lord thinks upon him—his help and deliverer, urged to make no delay.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine deliverance in the past does not exempt anyone from needing fresh deliverance in the present; the same God who set feet on a rock is the one still asked to “make haste to help.” True worship is fundamentally a willing heart shaped by God’s law, not primarily ritual performance—ultimately fulfilled in Christ’s own “Lo, I come.”

Application for life today.

Recall and name a specific past deliverance (a “new song” moment) before bringing a current need to God, following the psalm’s own order. Examine whether your obedience feels like mere ritual sacrifice or like verse 8’s delight—“thy law is within my heart.” When surrounded by “innumerable evils” right now, use verse 13’s bluntness as your own prayer: make haste to help me.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What is a “new song” moment of past deliverance you could recount to strengthen your faith for a present difficulty?

2. Where does your obedience currently feel more like obligation than the delight described in verse 8?

3. What specific trouble do you need to bring to God today with the same urgency as verses 13 and 17?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).